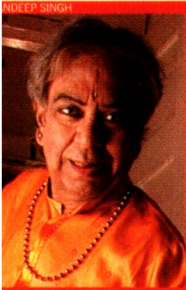


dance

ing—it is related to Indian history, temples and monuments,” says Oudiette. “I think it is very graceful and feminine. I enjoy the footwork, particularly,” says Cailleau, who has learnt ballet and salsa.

Like the scores of expats who think Indian dance forms have substance and have made India their

GURU SPEAK



Pandit Birju Maharaj

“Expats who come to learn Kathak under me are more determined than my Indian students. While my Indian students may back out on, say, a rainy day, most expats would show up for class. Of course, expats are hard to train as they

have to be introduced to our culture and language. A Chinese student of mine understood little English. When I would indicate that class is over, he would start dancing again. After this happened a few times, I got hold of a Chinese man and learnt to say ‘jesu’ meaning ‘stop’ in Chinese. Another student from Ghana was such a dedicated dancer that if I pointed out a mistake, he wouldn’t sleep at night, thinking he had to practise harder.”

home in order to master a form of their choice, Ekterina Buzunova knew she wanted to learn Bharatanatyam when she first saw a performance at the age of eleven. “I came for a tour to south India for a ballet performance when I was eleven. During that trip, I happened to see a Bharatanatyam performance and was enamoured by the idea of learning it,” says this 22-year-old Russian who is a trained ballet dancer.

“Fascinated by the idea of coming to India one day, I enrolled myself for Bharatanatyam classes in the Indian Culture Centre in Russia where I learnt the form for about five years. When I was 17, I applied

Fascinated by the idea of coming to India one day, I enrolled myself for Bharatanatyam classes in the Indian Culture Centre in Russia where I learnt it for 4-5 years.

EKTERINA BUZUNOVA,
Russia

for an ICCR scholarship.”

That’s how Buzunova started learning at Bharatiya Kala Kendra under renowned Bharatanatyam dancer Justin McCarthy and has been doing so for the past six years. She completes her post-graduate diploma in another year and then plans to head back home and teach the dance form there. “Russians are crazy about Indian movies, dance and culture. I’m confident my classes will be a huge success there,” says Buzunova who has performed in Delhi several times.

For now though, Delhi is home. And that’s not just because it is a cultural haven, with enough gurus and masters to teach the art. The other factor which makes the learning process easier for these ladies here is that the city is cosmopolitan. Given their deep interest, Indian dance is unlikely to be short of new students.

■ by Shruti Vashist



RAVI S SHARMA